

2026-09-06 — The Final Mincha, אָחוּת קִטְנָה, and the Chofetz Chaim's Primordial Oath

Independent review · read fresh, no exposure to the writing process · 6 September 2026

1. Overall Read

Hangs together — but as a garland rather than an argument. The organizing principle is chronological/liturgical (final מנחה → transition piyut → מעריב → שמונה עשרה → שחרית additions → (אבינו מלכנו)), and that scaffolding is clear. But the thesis is soft: the title promises three anchors — the final Mincha, אָחוּת קִטְנָה, the Chofetz Chaim's oath — and the piece delivers those plus five more sections, none of which is subordinated to the others. The result is nine handsomely written stops rather than a single sustained shiur. The 24 Elul / חתימה frame at the opening is strong; the coda about dancing on Simchas Torah for parnasa is genuinely disconnected. If one section had to justify the whole, it's V (the Chofetz Chaim's chiddush on the primordial oath) — that one earns its billing.

2. What Works

- **The opening frame (I-II).** The move — "the מחזור does not begin at ma'ariv; it begins with the מנחה that closes the year" — is a genuine reframing and lands on the first read. Pairing it with the חפץ חיים's yahrzeit gives the date real gravity.
- **The Reb Yoel Gross / Skverer Rebbe callout (II).** Best-crafted story in the piece. The two-generation structure (Reb Yoel learning it from the previous Skverer Rebbe) is what makes it land — not just a story about weeping, but a story about how a mesorah of weeping

travels.

- **The Chofetz Chaim chiddush (V).** The setup is patient: "when did any of us swear falsely?" is the exact question the reader is already asking. Footnote 10's note that ל"ח themselves quote 24:4 in the primordial-oath sugya is a strong support move — it converts the chiddush from novel to inevitable.
- **The Prague Haskalah play callout (VI).** Delivered with a straight face and the punchline lands. Restraint pays off here.
- **The תבילת pair (IV).** Showing both loci (תבילת and פותח את ידך) side by side is a satisfying "aha" — and the ethical turn ("we, in turn, must open our hands") saves it from being a curiosity.
- **Footnote 10 as a whole.** Notes that the Chofetz Chaim's chiddush is *already* latent in the gemara — this is exactly the kind of footnote work that upgrades the piece from summary to scholarship.

3. Where It's Weak or Could Be Sharper

- **The Simchas Torah coda (IX) is a non-sequitur.** The piece is about the opening of the ראש השנה — Section IX jumps three weeks forward to תשס"ח gathered only by "another סגולה" for parnasa." The concluding anecdote ("a man danced with abandon and his business flourished") sits uneasily as the last note of a shiur otherwise anchored in halacha and machshava. Consider cutting entirely, or moving to a footnote inside Section IV.
- **Section VII is doing three jobs at once.** It introduces four separate ימי additions, then pivots to a general kashya about תשס"ח the outer brachos, then delivers three teirutzim, then pivots again to the לתיים / לתיים distinction, then to the Bach's kasha, then to the halacha of omission. Any one of these could carry a section. Consider splitting VII into two — the halachic-permissibility question, and the practical dikduk question.

| **The Bach exchange (VII) resolves oddly.** The Bach's kasha is raised — "we
| say | םַּיִּם every day in | מֵעַרִיב and then answered by asserting the
| opposite, that our | נֶחֱם | םַּיִּם that's not a resolution; that's saying the
| Bach was working from a different | םֶה A sentence acknowledging that
| would close the loop.

| **Section VI's structural claim is unsupported.** "The | םֶה is exceedingly
| firm about no | םֶה then the fn11 flag admits the primary source is
| uncertain and points toward " | םֶה a rishon." That's a load-bearing
| citation and the piece's argument leans on it; the softness in the footnote
| undermines the confidence in the body.

| **"He would like to institute" language (III).** "A | םֶה the Rav would like to
| institute in the shul" is a pastoral aside that's stranded in an otherwise textual
| section. Either land it (with a sentence on *why* shul practice matters to this
| shiur) or trim.

| **Structural corresponding claim (VIII) is asserted, not shown.** " | אֲבִינו
| םֶה brachos correspond — not one-to-one, but strikingly — to the middle
| brachos" is a strong claim that would take two example pairings to demonstrate.
| Right now the reader is asked to take it on trust.

4.Factual / Citation Concerns

Rav Avraham Chazan and the Ramban hesped (fn4). The claim that

Rav Avraham Chazan was a contemporary of the Ramban *and* that "Rav

Avraham even delivered a hesped on him" needs verification — the

direction of the hesped, in particular, is worth pinning (some traditions

have the Ramban eulogizing him, not the reverse; some place Chazan as a

talmid). The fn already flags this. Recommend not printing until

confirmed.

The acrostic "	אֶבְרָהִם חֵזֶן חִזְקָה(III). The standard acrostic in	אחות
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חִזְקָה	אֶבְרָהִם חִזְקָהwith "	חִזְקָהbeing the conventional close of a
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piyut, not part of the mechaber's name. "	חִזְקָהas a compound
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identifier deserves a second look.

Nusach for the mizmor (IV). "	לְדוֹד מִזְמוֹר (תהילים כ"ד) — Tehillim 24
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opens	לְדוֹד מִזְמוֹרYes. Fine. But the	לְדוֹדsegulah is often
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described as being for the segment beginning specifically with those two

words as opposed to	לְדוֹדelsewhere. A one-line clarification
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would prevent confusion.

Vilna Gaon on	additions (fn16). The fn wisely flags this: תשובה
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"did not say" is stronger than sources support. The body should be

softened to match — currently reads as flatly "reportedly did not say

them."

Nusach comparison in VII. "	— this is וְהַעֲמִידֵנוּ מִלִּפְנֵי לַחַיִּים טוֹבִים
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מִן־הַסִּבְיָנוּ from	מִמַּעֲרִיב but different nuschaos vary on the vowelization.
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The Bach's assumption (that daily practice is	לַחַיִּים may reflect a
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specific edition. Worth a fn.

Rambam locus for Sephardi	אֶזְרָא יָשִׁיר (fn14). Flagged in fn. The	דגל
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מַרְיָאraiya is well-known but the specific Rambam locus is not

obvious in	הַלְכּוֹת תְּפִילָּה פֶּרֶק ז some place it in a teshuvah or in his
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liturgical rulings. Verify before print.

"	גמטריה (fn22). The fn admits "which specific	ראשון
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brings this gematria" is unknown. Given how central the claim is to

Section VIII's closing move, a source or a softer framing ("a widely-cited

rmez") would be safer.

5.Small Polish Suggestions

- Lead paragraph is a single 200+ word sentence-fragment run-on. Reads as a table of contents in prose. Break into 3 sentences, or replace with a genuine lead that stages the piece's central move.
- Section II: "In the rush of Erev Rosh HaShanah — the חקוה, last-minute preparations, physical הכנות" — the list has two items that mean the same thing. Trim one.
- Section III: "Two minutes of the piyut, powerfully framing the seam." Sentence fragment used as a landing. It works once; the piece uses this move (fragment as summation) five or six times, and it starts to feel like a tic.
- Section IV heading: "A famous סגולה, straight from the אריז"ל — "straight from" is casual for the register elsewhere. "Traced to the אריז"ל" or simply "from the אריז"ל" would sit better.
- Section V, opening line: "was troubled by the פשט — good. Two paragraphs later: "brings his דבר נפלא — the piece is signaling admiration a bit hard. Let the chiddush do the work; cut the adjective.
- Section VII heading: "a Sharp Halachic Careful" — "Careful" as a noun

doesn't quite work in English. "A Sharp Halachic Distinction" or "A Sharp Halachic Warning."

- "*sheine zach*," "*madgish*," "*daven far'n amud*" — Yiddish italics are used throughout, which is fine, but should be consistent. In some places they're italicized-and-untranslated; in others they're translated inline. Pick one.
- Colophon and lead both say "Second of three shiurim on the מחזור." One placement would do.
- Coda paragraph ("*Tomorrow, im yirtzeh Hashem...*") is fine, but currently sits *after* Section IX (which itself is a coda). Two codas dilute both. If IX stays, this coda should either lead into IX or replace it.

6.Bottom Line

| *A rich set of nine finely-written vignettes in search of a spine — the*
| *Chofetz Chaim chiddush and the final-Mincha frame are the two that earn*
| *top billing; cut or demote the Simchas Torah coda, split Section VII, and*
| *firm up the flagged citations (Chazan/Ramban, עק' בא' יסד' |* 7
| *gematria, Rambam locus) before print.*

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